

Firearms Trace Data: California - 2023

Data Source: Firearms Tracing System

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

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ATF Firearms Trace Data Disclaimer

Firearm traces are designed to assist law enforcement authorities in conducting investigations by tracking the sale and possession of specific firearms. Law enforcement agencies may request firearms traces for any investigative reason, and those reasons are not necessarily reported to the federal government. Not all firearms used in crime are traced and not all firearms traced are used in crime.

Firearms selected for tracing are not chosen for purposes of determining which types, makes or models of firearms are used for illicit purposes. The firearms selected do not constitute a random sample and should not be considered representative of the larger universe of all firearms used by criminals, or any subset of that universe. Firearms are normally traced to the first retail seller, and sources reported for firearms traced do not necessarily represent the sources or methods by which firearms in general are acquired for use in crime.

Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced in California in Calendar Year 2023

56,382

Firearm Types with a California Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

Pistols	36,552
Rifles	9,615
Revolvers	5,447
Shotguns	4,020
Receivers/Frames	212
Derringers	208
Other*	328

* Other includes Unknown Types, Machineguns, Machinegun Conversion Devices, Combinations, Silencers, Any Other Weapons, Destructive Devices and Flare Guns.

Top Calibers Reported on Firearm Traces with a California Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

9mm	21,812
.22 Cal	5,230
.40 Cal	5,093
.45 Cal	3,740

12GA	3,291
.38 Cal	2,430
.380 Cal	1,967
5.56mm	1,769
.223 Cal	1,417
.357 Cal	1,394

NOTE: There were 6,495 additional traces that were associated with other calibers. There were 1,744 traces with an unknown caliber.

Top Categories Reported on Firearm Traces with a California Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

Possession of Weapon	22,673
Weapon Offense	9,581
Found Firearm	3,089
Carrying Concealed Weapon	2,759
Firearm Under Investigation	2,731
Dangerous Drugs	2,016
Aggravated Assault	1,283
Homicide	1,143
Family Offense	1,116
Simple Assault	1,040

NOTE: There were 8,951 additional traces that were associated with other categories.

Top 15 Source States for Firearms with a California Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

California	18,402
Arizona	4,372
Nevada	2,065
Texas	1,662
Utah	631
Oregon	562
Georgia	470
Washington	455
Oklahoma	428
Florida	420
Idaho	346
Arkansas	332
Colorado	294
Missouri	279
New Mexico	258

NOTE: An additional 35 states, the District of Columbia, Guam and Puerto Rico accounted for 3,111 other traces. The source state was identified in 34,087 total traces.

Time-To-Crime Rates for Firearms with a California Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

Under 3 Months	1,297
3 Months to Under 7 Months	1,462
7 Months to Under 1 Year	1,698
1 Year to Under 2 Years	3,984
2 Years to Under 3 Years	4,308
3 Years and Over	21,265

1/1/2023-12/31/2023 California Average Time-to-Crime: **9.65 Years**

1/1/2023-12/31/2023 National Average Time-to-Crime: **6.76 Years**

Age of Possessors for Firearms with a California Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

17 and Under	1,737
18 to 21	4,158
22 to 24	3,305
25 to 30	6,866
31 to 40	11,117
41 to 50	7,306
Over 50	6,357

1/1/2023-12/31/2023 California Average Age of Possessor: **37 Years**

1/1/2023-12/31/2023 National Average Age of Possessor: **35 Years**

Top Recovery Cities for Firearms with a California Recovery

January 1, 2023 – December 31, 2023

Los Angeles	7,419
Sacramento	2,099
Fresno	2,064
San Bernardino	1,519
San Diego	1,396
Bakersfield	1,394
Oakland	1,386
Stockton	966
San Francisco	924
Chino Hills	666

NOTE: There were 918 additional municipalities that accounted for 36,495 other traces. The recovery city could not be determined for 54 traces.

Analytical Criteria Used to Compile the Enclosed Statistics

Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced

- Includes traces with a recovery state of California. Traces in which the recovery state was not provided were included when the requesting agency state was equal to California.
- Includes Firearms Recovered and Traced between 1/1/2023 –12/31/2023 or, if the recovery date was blank, firearms with trace entry dates between 1/1/2023 –12/31/2023.

- Duplicate traces, Firearms Not Recovered, Gun Buyback and Firearms Turned In are not included in this figure.
- Data was extracted from the Firearms Tracing System (FTS) on April 10, 2024.
- All traces may not have been submitted or completed at the time of this study.

Firearm Types and Calibers with a California Recovery

- Includes same criteria as Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced.

Top Categories Reported on Firearm Traces with a California Recovery

- Includes same criteria as Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced.

Top Source States for Firearms with a California Recovery

- Includes same criteria as Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced.
- Traces must identify a purchaser and the state in which the final dealer is located.

Time-to-Crime Rates for Firearms with a California Recovery

- Includes same criteria as Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced.
- Traces must identify a purchaser.
- Time-to-Crime was calculated for those traces in which the purchase date could be subtracted from the recovery date.

Age of Possessors for Firearms with a California Recovery

- Includes same criteria as Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced.
- Includes traces that provide a possessor and the possessor's date of birth.
- Possessor's age is calculated by subtracting the possessor's date of birth from the recovery date.

Top Recovery Cities for Firearms with a California Recovery

- Includes same criteria as Total Number of Firearms Recovered and Traced.
- Includes traces with a recovery city or, if the recovery city was not provided, traces requested by agencies with jurisdiction only within that city.

[View All 2023 Firearms Trace Data](#)

Last updated: December 9, 2024